wounded), the Chinese set about their other objective that was to have far-reaching political implications. Says Johri: ‘The immediate aim of the Chinese was to reconnoitre the area in the vicinity of the tri-junction of the Assam, Kameng and Bhutan boundaries so that if in the future the People’s Republic of China was required to describe the details of the tri-junction it could do so without difficulty. Here it may be pointed out that after the Chinese government pushed the Outer-Inner Tibetan boundary from the north of Rima to the north of Tawang it started claiming NEFA as a part of China. The main objection of the world powers [also repeated ad nauseam by Nehru] against this claim was that as no Chinese had put his foot on the territory, China could not claim it as her own. Chinese patrols, therefore, rushed towards the tri-junction in the vicinity of Kalaktang.’

It is indeed unfortunate that the mass slaughter of Indian troops after 21 November, the date of the ceasefire as declared by the Chinese, could never be taken up at an appropriate forum. With the area immediately south of Tenga being virtually impassable on foot, the bulk of the escaping troops had no option but to try and escape through the Morshing-Kalaktang route, where they were massacred in large numbers. Even the Chinese records brazenly talk of the various actions (including the killing of Brigadier Hoshiar Singh). Despite troops having been ordered to withdraw from the area, Chinese patrols continued to be sighted in the vicinity of Kalaktang even as late as mid-December.

Bertil Lintner in his book *Great Game East* comments: ‘As the Tibet issue had its cabal of pro-Chinese Western supporters, so did the Sino-Indian border dispute. Alistair Lamb, a British academic, and the Australian journalist Neville Maxwell both have published books arguing for the Chinese claim. They base their findings mainly on the fact that some British maps place the border at the foothills of the Himalayas, and that the text of the Simla Convention of 27 April 1914 was not included in the Aitchison’s Treaties, a 1929 official publication.’

Unfortunately, today there is a tendency among many Indian writers to blindly quote Maxwell in particular, who by virtue of having brought parts of the Henderson Brooks-Bhagat Report into the open is seen in some quarters as being the last word on the Indo-Sino conflict. Adds Lintner: ‘In the case of Maxwell, he lost his credibility when in the late 1960s he wrote a series of articles—“India’s Disintegrating Democracy”—in which he gives vent to his thundering misjudgements: “The great experiment of